

FEAR FACTOR

The suspects' connections with the National Health Service have led to strict checks on doctors from overseas, almost one-third of whom are Indians

Indian doctors were once universally acknowledged as the backbone of Britain's health system. But within days of the latest spate of July terror attacks across London and Glasgow, the National Health Service (NHS) has been labelled the "revolving door for terror". British Prime Minister Gordon Brown demanded an immediate review of the way NHS doctors are hired from abroad. Speaking during his first question time as prime minister in the House of Commons on July 4, Brown ordered Terrorism Minister Sir Alan West to carry out the review. He said background checks on skilled migrant workers will be expanded, and other fresh steps to counter terrorism will include a worldwide watchlist of terrorist suspects and a signed agreement with other countries to ensure a co-ordinated response.

As per the procedure currently followed, foreign doctors from outside the EU have to pass a series of rigorous linguistic and clinical tests before they can register with the General Medical Council. Employers can obtain details from the Criminal Records Bureau, but it only has British criminal records. They can also seek a "certificate of good standing" from a candidate's country of origin, but this is not a legal obligation. Foreigners face further checks before they can start working in British hospitals.

However, the disclosure that all eight people under arrest for their involvement in the terror attacks had links with the NHS has sent shockwaves. The NHS often depends on information provided by the authorities in unstable and even war-torn countries, and though the Department of Health has insisted that the existing checks are adequate, Brown's statement suggests there will be tighter security checks before work visas are granted. The Government had already made it harder for foreign doctors to get jobs in Britain by imposing new visa requirements last April, and giving priority to applicants from Europe. The Home Office's highly skilled migrant programme, used by hospitals to recruit medics, is also being toughened. Now doctors from overseas fear getting specialist medical training in the UK—the most prestigious stamp for Indian doctors for generations—will become tougher.

Nearly 90,000 doctors in the UK are of foreign origin and at 27,558, Indians constitute the largest contingent. The British Association of Physicians of Indian Origin (BAPIO), which looks after the interests of these doctors, has expressed alarm at the knee-jerk reaction. According to it, the security measures that are in place now are already very stringent. "Our biggest concern is that doctors must not be hassled in any way. There has to be a mechanism in place so that the NHS can work together with the intelligence services so that there is no need for blanket checks on all professionals," BAPIO President Dr Ramesh Mehta said. Dr Prasad Rao, chairman of the British International Doctors' Association, is concerned that patients may be alarmed by revelations about the doctors involved in the attempted attacks, and the government announcement of further vetting. "We have enjoyed the trust of the British public for the last 60 years," he said, "and hope to do so in future, but if these stories about overseas doctors keep coming up continuously, it could sow seeds of doubt."

by Aditi Khanna in London

vulnerability because of the specific nature of the UK's Islamic community. The fact that two-thirds of British Muslims are of Pakistani origin means that the tiny minority of those who might have ideas about seeking out training or direction from members of the 'Al Qaeda hardcore' in the borderlands of Pakistan and Afghanistan can more easily fulfil their ambitions. Nearly half a million people travel between the UK and Pakistan every year. "The one going for jihadi training is the needle in the haystack," said one source, "French or German militants simply find it far harder to get to anywhere that is useful for their purposes."

Certainly, previous attacks have proved the value of the 'X-factor' that an overseas link can bring. The pro-

REUTERS/DAVID MOIR



MINORITY VOICE Women holding anti-terror demonstration in Glasgow after the attack

gression from clumsy and large ammonium nitrate fertiliser and petrol bombs to much more sophisticated explosives is believed to have been the result of tuition by expert bomb-makers in camps in Pakistani tribal areas. Martyrdom videos recorded by the 7/7 bombers show volunteers taking bomb-making lessons at undisclosed locations believed to be in Waziristan. Mohammed Sadiq Khan, the leader of the 7/7 bombers, is thought to have been diverted from an original ambition to fight alongside the Taliban to the task of blowing up Britons in Britain by